Minna de Honkoku (みんなで翻刻)

What is Crowdsourcing?

Daren C. Brabham (2013) defines crowdsourcing as a phenomenon that emerged on the internet in the early 2000s, allowing "organisations to leverage the collective intelligence of online communities to serve business goals, improve public participation in governance, design products, and solve problems" (p. xix). Similarly, Dirk Riehle (2015) argues that crowdsourcing plays an integral role in open-source software development, particularly in community-owned projects maintained by volunteer contributors (pp. 25-26). Mozilla Firefox exemplifies volunteer-driven software development: "as bugs and security issues arise in the Firefox browser or as new features are desired, individuals in the Firefox community voluntarily program extensions, plug-ins, and new versions of the browser" (Brabham, 2013, p. 6). However, Brabham argues that Firefox does not strictly constitute crowdsourcing because "in its intended design, there is no top-down management of the project" (p. 6). This distinction highlights a key feature of crowdsourcing: organisations typically direct public participation toward a specific goal or task.

Within the humanities, Mia Ridge (2014) notes that crowdsourcing has become increasingly common, with libraries, archives, and museums using it to digitise large quantities of data. Ridge further argues that cultural heritage crowdsourcing projects are often motivated not by financial reward but by a desire to contribute to the public good. She also observes that some projects have moved away from the term "crowdsourcing" in favour of "micro-volunteering", which emphasises specialised contributions rather than the work of an anonymous crowd (pp. 2-4).

Tim Causer et al. (2018) note that cultural institutions have increasingly adopted crowdsourcing to "improve access to, and the quality of, their digital resources" (p. 1). Members of the public contribute by "tagging, identifying, text-correcting, annotating, and transcribing information, often creating new data in the process" (p. 1). More specifically, in the *Transcribe Bentham* project, Tim Causer and Melissa Terras (2014) explain that volunteers not only transcribe manuscripts but also encode important textual features using TEI XML (p. 63).

Aims and Purpose of This Project

Japan possesses a vast collection of historical documents from before and during the Edo period, including letters, diaries, and official records that provide valuable insights into the country's past. These materials are valuable not only to Japanese researchers but also to international scholars interested in Japanese history and culture. Historical records can also have practical applications, as documents describing past earthquakes, floods, and other natural disasters can inform contemporary disaster preparedness and risk management (Minna de Honkoku, n.d.).

Many of these sources, however, are written in *kuzushiji*, a cursive script that most contemporary readers find difficult to understand. To make these materials more accessible and suitable for digital analysis, they must be converted into modern text through a process known as transcription (*honkoku*). Traditionally, specialists in Japanese history, literature, and related disciplines have carried out this work. However, the vast number of surviving documents means that experts alone cannot realistically complete this task (Minna de Honkoku, n.d.).

The *Minna de Honkoku* project was established to address this challenge by encouraging public participation in transcribing historical materials. Founded in 2017 by the Research Group for Historical Earthquakes at Kyoto University, the project has attracted more than 10,000 participants and produced over 48 million transcribed characters, demonstrating crowdsourcing's potential to preserve and improve access to Japan's cultural heritage (Minna de Honkoku, n.d.).

The project closely reflects Brabham's (2013) definition of crowdsourcing. As Brabham argues, "the interplay between crowd and organisation is crucial for crowdsourcing because it ensures a mutually beneficial outcome that probably could not have existed without the cocreative efforts of both parties" (p. 2). This relationship is clearly visible in *Minna de Honkoku*, where volunteers contribute their time and skills while cultural institutions benefit from increased access to transcribed historical materials.

The project also aligns with Causer et al.'s (2018) argument that crowdsourcing can improve access to digital resources, as transcribing *kuzushiji* manuscripts makes historical documents easier to search, read, and analyse. Furthermore, the project exemplifies Ridge's (2014) observation that many cultural heritage crowdsourcing initiatives are driven by public benefit rather than financial incentives (pp. 2-4), as participants help preserve and expand access to Japan's historical record. In doing so, the project benefits both the public and the institutions responsible for preserving these materials by enabling large-scale transcription work that would otherwise be difficult to achieve.

Advantages and Disadvantages

Ridge (2014) argues that crowdsourcing in the cultural heritage sector benefits both researchers and the public by encouraging engagement with historical materials. However, greater public involvement can also shape a project's nature (pp. 2, 7). This advantage is evident in *Minna de Honkoku*, where participants learn about historical documents and *kuzushiji* while helping preserve them and improve access. Moreover, Brabham states that the speed and asynchronous nature of internet communication enables people to exchange ideas quickly and without any concern for location. It has also enabled people from various walks of life to participate in such projects without traditional barriers (pp. 11-16). For *Minna de Honkoku,* collaborators can work together across time zones, united by a common goal.

However, crowdsourcing projects also face several challenges. Causer and Terras (2014) note that volunteers may lose interest over time, causing projects to stagnate, particularly when tasks are complex or time-consuming (p. 67). This challenge is particularly relevant to *Minna de Honkoku* because reading and transcribing *kuzushiji* requires specialised knowledge and can intimidate beginners. Maintaining volunteer engagement is therefore essential to the project's long-term success, especially in a field that may be considered exotic to outsiders. Brabham states that "some studies suggest that individuals in participatory cultures are more likely and motivated to contribute content to various social media sites when they perceive that peers are consuming and valuing their content" (2013, p. 65).

Another concern identified by Causer and Terras (2014) is that volunteer contributions may not always match the quality of expert work, especially when interfaces or workflows are difficult to use (p. 83). In *Minna de Honkoku*, transcription errors may occur because participants have different skill and experience levels. Nevertheless, the project's collaborative nature allows multiple contributors to review and refine transcriptions, improving accuracy over time. However, Brabham cautions against calling people participating in such projects amateurs, as they can be highly qualified individuals who—if not seen as professionals—may be robbed of their legal rights (2013, pp. 69-71).

Similarly, Riehle (2015) argues that recruiting and retaining volunteers requires substantial effort and should not be taken for granted, as managing volunteer communities demands time and resources that could otherwise be devoted to project development (p. 27). Despite these challenges, *Minna de Honkoku's* success shows that crowdsourcing can be highly effective when a project offers clear goals, meaningful participation, and a tangible public benefit.

References

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